

PHISHING EMAIL ANALYSIS

REPORT

Introduction

Phishing is one of the most common forms of cyberattacks used by threat actors to steal sensitive information such as usernames, passwords, financial details, and personal data. These attacks are typically carried out through deceptive emails, messages, or websites that appear to originate from trusted organizations. By creating a sense of urgency, fear, or curiosity, attackers attempt to manipulate users into clicking malicious links, opening harmful attachments, or disclosing confidential information.

This report analyzes a suspected phishing email titled "Your Account Has Been Locked." The email claims that unusual login activity has been detected and urges the recipient to verify their identity immediately to avoid permanent account suspension. The purpose of this report is to identify the phishing indicators present in the email, assess the associated security risks, explain how the attack works, and provide practical prevention measures. Additionally, the report outlines recommended security practices, including employee do's and don'ts, to help individuals and organizations recognize and defend against phishing attempts.

Understanding the characteristics of phishing attacks and following established cybersecurity best practices are essential

steps in reducing the risk of account compromise, data breaches, and financial loss.

For example emails like-

Subject: Your Account Has Been Locked From: security-alert@account-verification-support.com

Message: Dear Customer, We detected unusual login activity on your account. For your security, your account has been temporarily locked. To restore access, please verify your identity immediately. Verify Your Account Now Failure to verify your account within 24 hours may result in permanent suspension.

Thank you,

Security Team

1. Phishing Email Analysis

Subject: *Your Account Has Been Locked*

From: security-alert@account-verification-support.com

1. Phishing Indicators	
Indicator	Why It's Suspicious
Generic greeting ("Dear Customer")	Legitimate organizations usually address users by name.

Unknown sender domain	account-verification-support.com does not clearly match a legitimate company's official domain.
Urgency and fear tactics	Claims of account lockout and permanent suspension are designed to pressure users into acting quickly.
Request for immediate verification	Phishing emails often ask users to verify credentials or personal information.
Vague account information	The email does not specify which account has been locked.
Suspicious call-to-action ("Verify Your Account Now")	Such links often redirect users to fake login pages.
Lack of company branding/contact details	Legitimate security notifications usually include official contact information and branding.

2. Email Risk Identification

Risk Level: HIGH

Potential Threats

- Credential theft (usernames and passwords)
- Identity theft
- Financial fraud

- Account compromise
- Malware infection through malicious links or downloads

Likely Attack Type

Credential Harvesting Phishing Attack

The attacker attempts to trick recipients into entering login credentials on a fake website that mimics a legitimate service.

3. Simple Explanation of How the Attack Works

1. The attacker sends a fake security alert email.
2. The victim becomes concerned because their account appears locked.
3. The victim clicks "**Verify Your Account Now.**"
4. The link opens a fake login page that looks legitimate.
5. The victim enters their username, password, or other sensitive information.
6. The attacker captures the information.
7. The attacker uses the stolen credentials to access accounts, steal data, or launch additional attacks.

4. Prevention Tips for Users

Before Clicking Any Link

- Check the sender's email address carefully.

- Hover over links to view the actual destination.
- Verify account issues by visiting the company's official website directly.
- Enable Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA).
- Keep browsers and security software updated.
- Report suspicious emails to the IT/Security team.

If You Clicked the Link

- Change your password immediately.
- Enable MFA if not already enabled.
- Monitor account activity.

5. Employee Do's and Don'ts

Do's

- ✓ Verify unexpected security alerts through official channels.
- ✓ Check sender domains carefully.
- ✓ Use strong, unique passwords.
- ✓ Enable MFA wherever possible.
- ✓ Report suspicious emails immediately.
- ✓ Follow company security awareness procedures.
- ✓ Contact IT support if uncertain.

Don'ts

- ✗ Do not click suspicious links.

- X Do not open unexpected attachments.
- X Do not provide passwords via email.
- X Do not trust urgent messages without verification.
- X Do not ignore phishing warning signs.
- X Do not reuse passwords across multiple accounts.
- X Do not forward suspicious emails to colleagues.

• **Security Awareness Summary**

This email exhibits several classic phishing characteristics: a generic greeting, suspicious sender address, urgency, threats of account suspension, and a request for immediate verification. The primary goal is likely to steal user credentials through a fake login page.

Employees should verify requests through official channels and report suspicious emails to their security team rather than interacting with them.